CHAPTER 4:

SETTING THE STAGE

Just as pivotal for the success of *Iron Man* as the quality of the acting, directing and special effects, the stagecraft had to create a convincing, realistic world for these fantastic characters to play against. If the surroundings aren't believable, it doesn't matter how Oscar® worthy any of the other components may be. The audience won't buy it.

But from the gala awards ceremony at Caesars Palace to the climactic battle that raged in the heart of Los Angeles, *Iron Man* was graced with set piece after set piece that allowed the film's wide-ranging and dynamic cast of characters the opportunity to move in grounded, believable environments.

We now move away from suits of armor and other high-tech concerns, and take you inside the design work behind the We now move away from suits of armor and other high-tech concerns, and take you inside the design work behind the film's many sets – from the treacherous desolation of Afghanistan's hinterlands and the cold claustrophobia of the Cave to the billionaire's splendor of the Stark Estate, where production designers modeled the exterior of the mansion to showcase Tony's enormous wealth and layered the interior to take filmgoers on an intimate journey into the mind of the hero.

The main character's environs are important for any movie to get right, but even more so for a protagonist like Tony Stark – whose mind is constantly abuzz with new ideas and concepts, and who riffs off the inspiration of his surroundings like an in-the-pocket jazz player. Whether it's inside the bowels of a cave or in the cocoon of his Workshop, the grounding of Tony's character was in the hands of the film's elite production designer, Michael Riva, who elevated the art of *Iron Man* to new levels.



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